

“ I BELIEVE IT IS PEACE FOR OUR TIME. ”

British prime minister Neville Chamberlain, on his return to London from the Munich Conference, September 30, 1938



Arab prisoners are guarded by a British soldier in the Old City of Jerusalem, during the suppression of the revolt against Britain's rule in Palestine.

“**appeasement**,” based on the belief that a durable peace could be secured by settling Germany’s “legitimate claims.” Attention focused on the German minority in Czechoslovakia, concentrated in the **Sudetenland** area. Hitler stirred up unrest among the Sudeten Germans, while ordering his generals to prepare for an invasion of Czechoslovakia. The British and French governments were desperate to avoid war, but were committed to defending the Czechs. In September, Chamberlain embarked on an unprecedented diplomatic initiative, flying twice to Germany for **face-to-face talks with Hitler**. Although Britain pressured the Czech government into making major concessions, this only made Hitler raise his demands.

10,000,000 THE APPROXIMATE ADDITION TO THE GERMAN POPULATION BY THE ANNEXATIONS OF AUSTRIA AND SUDETENLAND

War seemed inevitable, and military preparations were under way in Britain and France when, on September 28, Italian dictator **Benito Mussolini** proposed a **four-nation conference**. Hitler accepted and met the French premier Édouard Daladier (1884–1970), Chamberlain, and Mussolini at Munich. A deal was

struck that preserved peace at the expense of Czechoslovakia, which had to **hand over the Sudetenland** to Germany. Chamberlain and Daladier were greeted as heroes when they returned home, the British and French people profoundly relieved to have avoided war. Conservative MP Winston Churchill (1874–1965) was among the minority who **denounced the Munich agreement**, calling it “a defeat without a war.”

Post-Munich optimism only lasted until November, when **Kristallnacht** (“the Night of Broken Glass”) provided graphic evidence of the extremist nature of the Nazi regime.

Steam record holder

Designed by Nigel Gresley, the steam locomotive **Mallard** was a masterly fusion of form and function. It achieved an enduring world speed record.



Night of broken glass

A shopkeeper clears up shattered glass from a looted Jewish shop in the wake of attacks on German and Austrian Jews in November.



children, without their parents, and the US maintained its existing barriers to immigration. **Jews were trapped** because, although the Nazis were ready to let them leave, they had nowhere to go.

One potential destination for Jews from Europe was **Palestine**, which was recognized by the British

as a site for a **Jewish homeland** (see 1917). But the British were struggling with an armed uprising by **Palestinian Arabs** who were **bitterly opposed** to the expansion of Jewish settlement. In an attempt to defuse the situation, Britain imposed tight limits on Jewish immigration.

The high pitch of anxiety in the world at the time became evident when a radio broadcast induced **mass panic** in the US. Orson Welles’s radio version of the alien-invasion classic **The War of the Worlds** was broadcast by CBS at Halloween. The news bulletin format convinced millions of Americans that a genuine invasion by Martians was underway. When genuinely frightened listeners finally understood their mistake, there was widespread anger.

The assassination of a German diplomat by a Jew in Paris served as a pretext for Nazi-orchestrated attacks on Jewish homes and businesses across Germany and Austria. Synagogues were burned down and sacred objects desecrated; 30,000 Jewish men were rounded up and taken to concentration camps, where beatings and torture were routine.

Those countries still committed to democracy and freedom expressed **outrage at Nazi anti-Semitism**, but they were not keen to provide a home for Jews now desperate to escape Nazi persecution. At an **international conference** on the issue held at Evian in July, the Australian representative T. W. White stated bluntly: “As we have no racial problem, we are not desirous of importing one.” Britain agreed to accept a limited number of Jewish

